

in Dubai, which boasts of investment by some of the biggest names in Bollywood. These men were contracted at 20 dirhams (Rs 200) an hour but didn't mind what they got in hand after the middlemen took their share, only half. "We worked about 12 hours a day and even on public holidays including Fridays and made up to Rs 75,000 a month," says Rajan Nepolean, another native who lost his job due to this sudden downturn. Real estate projects by the corporate construction giant Emaar (which is building the world's tallest building—the 2,684-foot Burj Dubai—and the new Downtown Dubai) too have been put on hold, forcing hundreds of South Asians, mostly Keralites, to return to their home countries. According to Morgan Stanley, around \$263 billion worth of real estate projects in the Gulf countries are either delayed or have been cancelled since last November.

Many of these jobless men who have returned are now working as fishermen for a paltry Rs 250 a day; others loiter around the local church and beaches. "I am working as a coolie making Rs 150 a day now as I have no savings to take care of my expenses," says 31-year-old Jose Henry, who was earlier employed by a Dutch company in Sharjah. Most of the people in Sakthikulangara have completed school education but are not trained for anything except fishing-related jobs. "In the days to come, this place will face serious economic and social repercussions with the increasing return migration. The local fishing

(LEFT) MANY RE-TRENCHED WORKERS HAVE RETURNED TO TAKE UP JOBS AS FISHERMEN AT RS 250 A DAY AS COMPARED TO RS 200 PER HOUR IN THE GULF (BELOW)

20 lakh Keralites work abroad, 90 per cent of them in the Gulf region.

Rs 110 crore has been set aside for a rehabilitation package for the returnees.

Rs 40,000 crore is the annual remittance Kerala gets from Gulf.

industry which faced a serious shortage of labour after young men left for the Gulf will now look up," says John Cyril, a lawyer.

It's a problem that is likely to affect not just this little village but all of Kerala in the near future. More than 20 lakh emigrants from Kerala work abroad with 90 per cent of them in the Gulf region, accounting for 25 emigrants per 100 households. More than 60 per cent of these non-resident Keralites hold blue-collar jobs, and their annual remittances to their families in Kerala have crossed Rs 40,000-crore mark, twice the state's total tax revenue annually. The state also accounts for more than a quarter of NRI remittance to India. "We could end up with half-a-million Malayalees coming back in the months to come. There could be an exodus next month after the schools close," says Thomas Isaac, state finance minister, who announced a Rs 110-crore rehabilitation package for the returnees last week.

Union Minister of Overseas Indian Affairs Vayalar Ravi, who also hails from Kerala, has told INDIA TODAY that he has taken up with the Prime Minister the need to formulate a comprehensive package to rehabilitate the returnees. "There is a great dip in employment opportunities there. The number of group visas issued to Gulf countries by the External Affairs Ministry fell from 2,286 in January 2008 to just 265 in December," he said. The Pravasi Malayali Welfare Association says that on an average 300 people return to Kerala daily. According to the state Government's Overseas Development and Employment Promotion Consultants (ODEPEC), there has been a considerable drop in the number of visas issued. "There is a 50 per cent drop in the job visas issued from the Gulf and passenger traffic to that region since December," says K.V. Muralidharan of the Kerala Travel Agents Association.

Pathanamthitta district, which has a large number of its populace settled in the Gulf and the US, is also feeling the tremors of the meltdown. "There is panic all over. Real estate prices are crashing. Many of those who had taken loans from banks here to start businesses in Gulf have delayed repayments. There could soon be suicides similar to those of the farmers," says George Mathew, manager, Federal Bank, in Tiruvalla, a town which has the country's highest density of banks and ATMs. "Not just blue-collar construction workers but even middle-class employees in banks have lost their high-paying jobs in the Gulf. Left with few options, they

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